Freekeh Bi Djeij

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

Fragrant Freekeh with Chicken & Golden Nuts Freekeh has a lovely smoky flavour that makes this dish especially comforting. Cooked in fragrant chicken broth, the grains become tender while keeping...

Serves 6–8 · Prep 25 min · Cook 1 h 15

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE CHICKEN AND BROTH

- 1 whole chicken, approximately 1.5–1.8 kg, jointed
- 1 large onion, quartered
- 2 cinnamon sticks
- 3 bay leaves
- 5 cardamom pods, lightly crushed
- Approximately 2½ litres water or chicken broth, enough to cover
- 1 tsp salt, adjusted according to the broth
- ½ tsp black pepper

FOR THE FREEKEH

- 3 cups coarse freekeh
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 large onion, finely chopped
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp black pepper
- Salt, to taste
- Reserved chicken broth, as needed according to the freekeh packet instructions

FOR THE NUT TOPPING

- 2 tbsp olive oil
- ¼ cup walnut pieces
- ¼ cup cashew nuts
- ¼ cup shelled pistachios
- ¼ cup pine nuts
- ¼ cup blanched almonds

METHOD

1. Prepare the chicken broth. Place the chicken pieces, quartered onion, cinnamon sticks, bay leaves and cardamom in a large pot. Add enough water or broth to cover, followed by the salt and black pepper.
2. Bring gently to a simmer, skimming off any foam. Partially cover and cook over low heat for approximately 40–50 minutes, until the chicken is tender and cooked through. Remove individual pieces earlier if they are ready.
3. Transfer the chicken to a dish and spoon over a little broth to keep it moist. Strain the remaining broth, discarding the onion and whole spices. Keep hot.
4. Prepare the freekeh. Spread it on a tray and check carefully for small stones or debris. Rinse thoroughly in several changes of water, then drain.
5. Soften the onion. Heat the olive oil in a large, heavy saucepan over medium heat. Add the chopped onion and cook for approximately 7–10 minutes, until softened and lightly golden.
6. Stir in the cumin, ground cinnamon and black pepper. Add the drained freekeh and stir for 1–2 minutes to coat the grains.
7. Cook the freekeh. Add hot reserved broth in the quantity recommended on the packet. Taste the liquid and adjust the salt. Bring to a gentle simmer, cover and cook over low heat until tender but still pleasantly chewy, approximately 30–45 minutes for coarse freekeh. Check occasionally and add more hot broth if needed.
8. Remove from the heat and leave covered for 10 minutes, then gently fluff with a fork.
9. Toast the nuts. Meanwhile, heat the olive oil for the topping in a frying pan over medium-low heat. Toast the nuts in separate batches, stirring frequently, until lightly golden. Remove promptly from the pan.
10. Assemble and serve. Remove the chicken skin and bones, if desired, and pull the meat into generous pieces. Warm gently in a little broth if needed. Spoon the freekeh onto a wide platter, arrange the chicken over it and finish with the toasted nuts.

Tip

Check the freekeh before rinsing. Spread it out so you can easily spot any small stones.